

ENGLISH, POWER, ACCESS

Orwell And Political Language

WORDS CAN HIDE RESPONSIBILITY



Why Orwell cared

POLITICAL PURPOSE

Expose lies

Declared democratic
socialism.

HISTORICAL MOMENT

Defend truth

Empire · Purges · Bombing

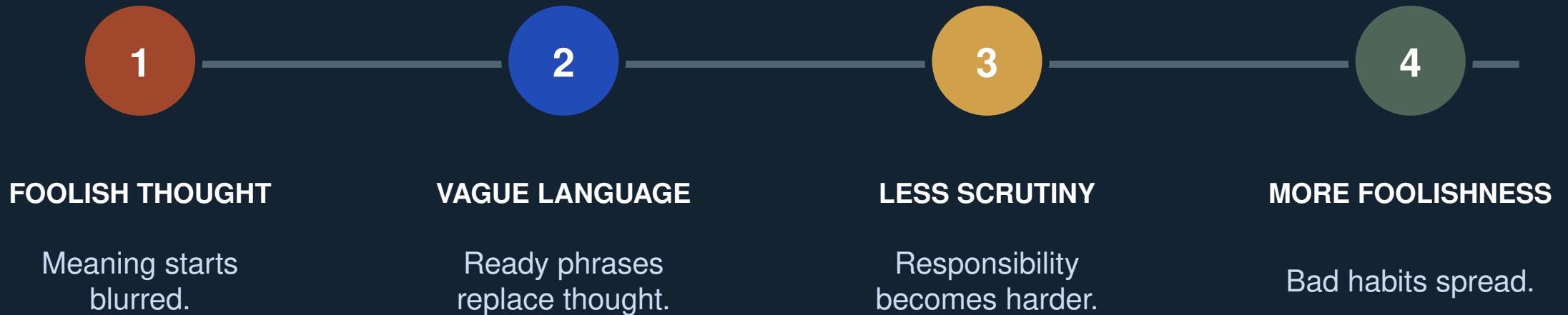
WRITING AIM

Create art

Politics needed honest
form.

He wrote as partisan.

His central feedback loop



The loop is reversible.

Better choices require effort.

How language conceals harm

EUPHEMISM

“Pacification”



Villages bombed.

ABSTRACTION

“Population transfer”



People expelled.

DEPERSONALISATION

“Elements eliminated”



Prisoners killed.

Concrete verbs restore responsibility.

Orwell's six working rules

1

Drop stale figures.

2

Prefer shorter words.

3

Cut spare words.

4

Prefer active voice.

5

Replace needless jargon.

6

Break rules when needed.

Meaning comes first.

What later evidence supports

FIVE EXPERIMENTS

Crime metaphors shifted choices.

Placement changed effects.

Participants missed influence.

LIMITS

One topic.

Five experiments.

No universal proof.

Words can steer attention.

Criticism: rules need judgment

TRUTH

Plain prose can lie.

VOICE

Passive voice can help.

IMAGERY

Fresh metaphors clarify.

ABSTRACTION

Abstract terms can matter.

PROOF

Rules never prove truth.

Orwell anticipated several limits.

A practical reading test

01

Who acts?

02

**What
happened?**

03

**Who
suffers?**

04

**Which
words
soften?**

05

**Which
facts
verify?**

ORWELL FOUNDATION · 1946 ESSAYS

PLOS ONE · 2011 STUDY

Clarity begins accountability.

NEXT: The English language business